

Creative Thinking

Executive MBA 60

Course Overview

In a world of rapid technological and product-market change, the ability to constantly refresh existing or introduce new product and service offerings, and continuously improve processes and practices is an indispensable element of sustained competitive advantage. Leaders who have mastered the skills of creative thinking and can foster those skills in others are therefore in a position to add great value to their firms and, ultimately, to society. This course is designed to help you understand and begin to master those skills.

My approach builds on the assumption that human creativity is not a mystical and indeterminate ability but, rather, results from understandable and replicable activities that increase the probability of creative outcomes. It is therefore possible for anyone to become more creative and to build the habits and skills of creativity into their own work and into the organizations they lead. We will articulate those skills, drawing from both scientific evidence as well as specific case studies of creative people and creative organizations. We will also engage in a variety of experiential activities designed to help you start building your own creative repertoire.

Course Grade

Your grade will be determined based on the following course requirements:

- | | |
|--|-----|
| – Informed participation in discussion (includes attendance) | 1/2 |
| – Idea pitch report | 1/2 |

The grading scale for each course requirement is as follows:

- | | |
|-------------------------------|-----|
| – Failed to meet expectations | (0) |
| – Barely met expectations | (1) |
| – Fulfilled expectations | (2) |
| – Exceeded expectations | (3) |

1. **High Pass.** You must receive “Exceed expectations” in both requirements.
2. **Pass.** You must receive “Fulfilled expectations” (or higher) in one requirement and no lower than “Barely met expectations” in the other.
3. **Low Pass.** If you receive “Barely met expectations” in both course requirements, you will receive a “Low Pass.”
4. **No Pass.** If you receive a “Failed to meet expectations” in any part of your work, you will not pass the course.

Course Requirements

Pre-course preparation. Your success in this course depends upon preparation prior to and during our sessions. I have chosen a number of readings to accompany the course. Please make sure that you read all assigned readings prior to our first meeting and use the evening between classes to refresh your memory by reviewing the readings to be discussed the following day.

In addition, there are two assessments that I would like you to complete.

1. The first is a creative self-assessment that captures the various creative behaviors and allows you to compare yourself to successful innovators. The assessment can be accessed by clicking on the following link:
http://olinbusiness.ut1.qualtrics.com/SE/?SID=SV_6z2rCb2ETmgySnr
2. The second is a social network assessment. This assessment allows you derive a score as to how densely connected your social network is. We will discuss this score in class. Please be comprehensive in entering your network contacts. The assessment can be accessed by clicking on the following link:
https://apps.olin.wustl.edu/forms/network_assessment/

Informed participation in discussion. The quality of our learning experience depends substantially on the level of informed participation during our sessions. My evaluation of the quality of your contribution is a function of whether your comments:

- Reflect an accurate and thoughtful understanding of the topic;
- Don't just repeat or rephrase what others already have said;
- Provide new insight or draw on relevant personal/professional experiences;
- Move our discussion in new and productive directions;
- Rely on facts, evidence, and logic (not just opinion); and,
- Contribute to an environment of open dialogue and informed debate.

Attendance. Your attendance at all sessions is expected. I recognize that circumstances beyond your control may require you to miss a session or some part of a session. That is the nature of life as an executive.

- If you miss a half-day, your grade may be reduced one level. So, if apart from attendance you would have earned a "Pass" you will instead receive a "Low Pass." If you miss a full day of class, you will receive a "No Pass."

Course Requirements

Idea development report. The goal of this report is to provide you an opportunity to start working on an idea (or refine an already existing idea) that you would like to pitch. The 7 skills introduced in class are those practiced by successful innovators and are key to you being able to consistently develop and sell your new ideas. Thus, in preparation for your report, I am asking you to systematically practice these skills, as well as their associated techniques:

1. **Associating**—combining ideas/concepts from disparate knowledge domains (technique: brut force, identify analogous problem domains)
2. **Observing**—seeing the world with fresh eyes to generate new understandings or to test untested assumptions (e.g., Oral-B, Old Spice) (technique: think like an anthropologist)
3. **Questioning**—challenging every assumption (technique: reverse assumptions) and using constraints to structure the solution space (technique: suggestive/prohibitive constraints & 21 great questions)
4. **Networking**—seeking out social intersections by reaching out to people who are otherwise disconnected (technique: activate your dormant ties)
5. **Experimenting**—trying out your ideas and testing assumptions underlying them by creating dirty prototypes of your new product, service, process, or procedure (technique: rapid prototyping)
6. **Teaming**—harnessing the power of diverse teams by imposing a structured process and instilling appropriate team norms (technique: hybrid approach to brainstorming)
7. **Pitching**—selling your ideas so that they become sticky (technique: SUCCES formula)

The deliverable for this requirement is a **4-page (double-spaced) report**. Your report should address the following key aspects:

- Describe how you used the 7 skills in the development/refinement of your idea. Offer concrete examples for each of the 7 skills (or their associated techniques)

The paper is due **6 weeks from the last day of class**. You should email your paper to baer@wustl.edu. Please name your file with the convention, “Last name, First name” (e.g., “Baer, Markus”).

Honor code. Your participation as a member of the course obligates you to follow the provisions of the Olin Business School Honor Code with respect to academic integrity and professionalism.

Course Materials

Course Packet. This will be made available to you prior to the beginning of the course:

1. Dyer, J. H., Gergesene, H. B., & Christensen, C. M. (2009). The innovator's DNA. *Harvard Business Review*, 87 (12), 60–67.
2. Catmull, E. (2008). How Pixar fosters collective creativity. *Harvard Business Review*, 86 (9), 64–72.
3. Coyne, K. P., Clifford, P. G., Dye, R. (2007). Breakthrough thinking from inside the box. *Harvard Business Review*, 85 (12), 70–78.
4. McGrath, R. G. (2011). Failing by design. *Harvard Business Review*, 89 (4), 76–83.
5. Thomke, S. (2020). Building a culture of experimentation. *Harvard Business Review*, 98 (2), 40–47.
6. Whitfield, J. (2008). Group theory. *Nature*, 455 (9), 720–723.
7. Baer, M. & Zhang, J. H. (2024). Discerning creativity: A group process perspective on idea selection. *Innovation*, 26 (3), 387–400.
8. Heath, C & Heath, D. (2007). What sticks? In *Made to stick: Why some ideas survive and others die* (pp. 3–24).

Course Instructor

Markus Baer, Ph.D.

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Dr. Markus Baer is an award winning teacher, scholar, and professor of organizational behavior at the Olin Business School. He earned his M.A. in psychology from the Justus-Liebig-University in Giessen, Germany and his Ph.D. from the University of Illinois at Urbana-Champaign. Prior to pursuing his Ph.D., he was part of the founding team of a successful consulting start-up.



Dr. Baer has won accolades for his teaching, both from the Olin Business School, where he won consecutive teaching awards and internationally as one of the world's top 40 business professors under 40. He teaches courses on organizational behavior (with a specific focus on team dynamics) and creativity/innovation across a variety of programs, including the BSBA, MBA, and Executive MBA programs in St. Louis, Shanghai, and Mumbai as well as WashU @ Brookings in Washington D.C.

Dr. Baer's research, which can be found in the leading academic journals, has won multiple awards, including winning the "Olin Award Recognizing Research That Transforms Business." A sought after speaker, Dr. Baer is recognized as one of the leading thinkers on the topic of creativity in organizations and has engaged a wide range of audiences, both in the private and public sectors (e.g., CIA, DOI, NASA, ONI) on this topic.

Day 1

1:30 – 4:30 p.m.

Understanding Creativity: Foundations & Framework

We will begin our discussion by diving into the science of human creativity to understand what is known about where creative ideas come from. We will discover that creativity is not some mystical, indeterminate ability but, rather, that it results from identifiable and replicable skills and habits that can be emulated—habits that will form the basis for the remainder of this course. We will then identify what these replicable skills and habits are and how they can be nurtured. To this end, we will study one company that has managed to produce an impressive string of creative successes—Pixar. We will also discuss your results from the “Creator’s Assessment” as part of this session.

Case discussion: “How Pixar Fosters Collective Creativity”

Questions to think about as you read this case:

- a. What are the key ingredients to Pixar’s success?
- b. Which tools/practices can you transfer to your own work right now?
- c. Link what Pixar does to the Innovator’s DNA!

Assessment: Creativity Self-Assessment

Please bring your results from the Creator’s Assessment. This assessment is taken online:

http://olinbusiness.ut1.qualtrics.com/SE/?SID=SV_6z2rCb2ETmgySnr

4:30 – 6:00 p.m.

Nurturing Creativity: Associating

In this session, we will begin our in-depth analysis of the various creativity skills by focusing on the skill of ASSOCIATING. In addition, we will learn specific tools to help apply this skill.

Day 2

1:30 – 3:30 p.m.

Nurturing Creativity: Observing & Questioning

In this session, we will explore the importance of QUESTIONING—asking the right questions as a critical tool for developing fresh ideas and creating the constraints within which creativity can flourish.

3:30 – 6:00 p.m.

Nurturing Creativity: Networking

We will continue our examination of different creativity skills by exploring the importance of NETWORKING. We will utilize your results from the “Social Network Assessment” in our discussion. In addition, we will explore one particular strategy for strengthening your social network.

Assessment: Social Network Assessment

Please bring to class your results from the Social Network Assessment. This assessment is taken online:

https://apps.olin.wustl.edu/forms/network_assessment/

Day 3

1:30 – 2:30 p.m.

Nurturing Creativity: Experimenting

In this session, we will examine the importance of EXPERIMENTING and prototyping for creative outcomes.

2:30 – 4:30 p.m.

Nurturing Creativity: Teaming

In this session will explore the critical role that teams play in the creative process. In addition, we will learn some TEAMING skills and will work to practice and apply those skills.

4:30 – 6:00 p.m.

Nurturing Creativity: Idea Selling

In the final session of the day, we will practice our idea pitching skills. This will serve as a primer for your project pitches later on in the program.